



JUSTIN TSENG
City Councilor

City of Medford

OFFICE OF THE CITY COUNCIL

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To: City Clerk Richard Eliseo
From: Councilor Justin Tseng
Re: **Preliminary Budget Requests for FY2027**

Dear Clerk Eliseo,

I am writing to submit my preliminary budget priorities for FY2027.

Cities like Medford find themselves in a challenging period. Rising costs, tariffs, uncertainty in federal funding, and decades of systemic underinvestment continue to put pressure on municipal budgets. These forces are largely outside our control, but their effects are felt directly by our residents and our city government.

At the same time, Medford has made meaningful progress. Last term, residents voted to make historic investments in our public schools and in our streets and sidewalks. Those investments are already helping stabilize critical school programs and allowing the City to begin addressing long-standing infrastructure needs. *We must maintain this progress by supporting the School Committee and Department of Public Work's full budgetary requests.* We must now also look ahead to reimagining key community hubs like pursuing badly needed repairs to our High School.

The work ahead is to build on our progress while preparing for the challenges that may come. Budgets are statements of our values and aspirations. Those remain clear: ensuring Medford is a city where people can build their lives, shape their neighborhoods, and know that their government works for them.

With that in mind, I respectfully offer the following priorities for consideration as the Council deliberates and Administration prepares the FY2027 budget proposal.

I. Strengthening City Capacity, Financial Sustainability, and Affordability

A. Establish a Grant Writer / Grants Manager Position

As municipal budgets tighten, it is increasingly important that Medford maximize outside funding opportunities. A dedicated grant writer could help departments pursue state, federal, and philanthropic funding while managing compliance and reporting requirements. Even one successful grant could offset the cost of the position while bringing in additional resources.

Looking ahead, the City should also explore investments in operational capacity, such as data and performance analysis to track service delivery, digital service improvements like better online permitting and service request tracking, and project management capacity to help departments move major capital projects forward efficiently and to operate a volunteer hub for residents who wish to contribute to our community.

B. Provide Assessing Department Staffing to Implement a Residential Exemption

The Council has long indicated interest in pursuing a Residential Exemption to help stabilize housing costs for Medford residents. The Assessing Department has indicated that implementing this program would require one to two additional full-time staff members to process applications, with an estimated impact of \$100,000–\$200,000. Ensuring the department has this capacity will allow the City to deliver on a commitment aimed at helping residents remain in the community they call home.

At the same time, the City should continue funding the Affordable Housing Trust Fund and efforts to increase housing supply, including the citywide zoning project.

II. Investing in Safe and Reliable Infrastructure

A. Increase Funding for DPW, Engineering, and Facilities

As Medford addresses years of infrastructure backlog, we must ensure departments have the resources to keep our streets safe and well maintained.

Priority investments include:

- Implementing recommendations from the Medford Bicycle Advisory Commission, including hiring a traffic engineer focused on walking, biking, and transit to advance Vision Zero and Complete Streets initiatives.
- Increasing DPW staffing to address restriping, signal timing improvements, pothole repair, and maintenance backlog.
- Providing adequate funding for road safety markings, signage, and related equipment.

These investments will help ensure that recent infrastructure funding translates into safer streets and more reliable public works.

B. Improve Snow and Sidewalk Plowing Capacity

Reliable winter operations are essential for public safety and accessibility. The City should consider investments in equipment that would allow DPW to improve street and sidewalk plowing operations so residents, schools, and businesses can move safely during winter storms.

C. Support Tree Planting and Canopy Expansion

Tree canopy is critical for neighborhood livability, climate resilience, and public health. As the City receives its Urban Forest Management Plan, we should begin planning for expanded tree planting and stewardship, including funding for a half-time volunteer coordinator to support community volunteer tree planting initiatives.

III. Strengthening Public Safety

A. Fund Fire Department Dive Team Training and Equipment

Given Medford's extensive waterways that we are so fortunate to enjoy, establishing a dive team within the Fire Department would strengthen emergency response capabilities and

ensure first responders have the training and equipment necessary to respond to water-related emergencies. Previous estimates put this at \$122,933.

At the same time, several of the City's fire stations continue to require repairs and long-term capital improvements, which should remain a priority.

IV. Expanding Access and Inclusion in City Services

A. Stabilize Funding for the Medford Family Network

The Medford Family Network (MFN) provides important resources and programming for families with young children. In light of the loss of external funding streams, we should support the MFN in their efforts to maintain the staffing and programming capacity that many families rely on and which help families save on household expenses.

B. Fund Recreation and Inclusion Staff Positions

Through ongoing conversations with residents with disabilities and their families, several gaps in city services have been identified. Funding a Therapeutic Recreation Specialist, a Recreation Department Office Manager, and a Citywide Inclusion Specialist, at an estimated cost of approximately \$200,000, would expand access to city programming and ensure residents of all abilities can participate fully in community life.

C. Maintain Funding for the Community Liaison Program

The Community Liaison Program has strengthened connections between City Hall and Medford's diverse communities. Maintaining funding for these positions will help ensure residents continue to have a voice in local government and help the City protect our residents from federal encroachment on their rights. The City's partnership with the Greater Malden Asian American Community Coalition to expand outreach to Medford's AAPI community is a promising step forward for the program.

The success of the Community Liaison Program provides a strong jumping off point that could create more community events for the City to help in navigating complicated applications for social services and public benefits, like financial aid and energy efficiency programs, which can help residents who are traditionally overlooked to cut costs. Further funding could expand this to the broader public.

V. Supporting Civic Life and Community Identity

A. Create a Dedicated Local Arts Investment Line Item (\$80,000)

Medford's arts and cultural organizations help shape the identity and vibrancy of our city. In the most recent grant cycle, more than 60 percent of requests—representing roughly \$125,000 in proposed programming—went unfunded. A modest municipal investment could support performances, public art, festivals, and other community programming that bring residents together and activate public spaces.

B. Re-establish a Cultural Affairs Staff Position

To support this work, the City should consider re-establishing a Cultural Affairs staff position with a modest operating budget to coordinate arts programming, streamline permitting, and support events such as Medford Open Studios, public art installations, and performances at venues including the Condon Shell, Chevalier Theatre, and Arts Collaborative Medford. Investing in arts means investing in community.

C. Pilot a Neighborhood Placemaking Fund

Finally, I recommend piloting a small neighborhood placemaking fund in the range of \$25,000–\$50,000. Small grants for murals, community gardens, neighborhood events, benches, and other improvements can have an outsized impact in helping residents shape the places in which they live.

VI. Protecting Quality of Life

The City should continue supporting programs that directly affect residents' quality of life, including rodent prevention and sanitation efforts. Maintaining reliable waste services—including weekly waste pickup—remains important for protecting neighborhood health and livability.

VII. Looking Ahead

This list of priorities is admittedly extensive, and surely underinclusive. The challenges facing our city, however, are significant, and the opportunities to strengthen our community are real. Many of these investments are modest in cost but meaningful in impact, helping protect the progress we have made while positioning Medford for the years ahead.

As in previous years, I encourage the Council to create and distribute a public input survey so residents can share their priorities directly with the Council and Administration.

Medford has always been shaped by the people who live here—their ideas, their creativity, and their commitment to their community. Our role as a local government is to create the conditions that allow residents to shape the future of the city they call home.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Justin Tseng', with a stylized flourish at the end.

Justin Tseng, Medford City Councilor